STATUS REPORT

Congo — digital transformation and data governance status report

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ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Congo has depended on the single WACS submarine cable since 2012, and weeks of outages in early 2026 pushed the regulator ARPCE to demand a switch to an alternative cable within three weeks (January 2026). A month later ARPCE launched a government data centre at Pointe-Noire to serve the 2Africa cable landing (February 2026).

Quality of service is a live regulatory fight. Drive tests across twenty interior localities in February 2026 found Airtel Congo with no 4G service in five of them, and in April 2026 ARPCE issued a formal mise en demeure to MTN Congo and Airtel Congo requiring them to correct network shortfalls under threat of sanction. Ahead of the March 2026 elections it had already required faultless performance and national roaming so coverage gaps would not cut voters off.

The underlying position is thin. ITU data record 31% of individuals using the internet in 2023, and ARPCE counted 5.9m mobile subscriptions and 3.4m mobile-internet subscriptions the same year. The Ibrahim Index scores Congo 3.7 out of 100 on internet and computer access in 2023, 52nd of 54 African states and barely moved in a decade; mobile communications, up 13.3 points to 52.3 and one of its most improved indicators, still ranks 44th of 54. Domestic traffic has one exchange point, CGIX-BZV in Brazzaville, managed by ARPCE (2024).

Public money is going in faster than sites are going up. The PATN is a joint government and World Bank operation worth US$100m, and its steering committee set the 2025 budget at just over XAF 21bn (March 2025); the mid-term review judged the project "peu satisfaisant", with only twenty broadband connectivity sites operational after two years (October 2025). The universal access fund FASUCE is appropriated XAF 1bn for 2026. The older Chinese-financed backbone programme stalled when falling oil prices left Congo unable to service its China Eximbank debt, and was still under implementation in April 2022.

Costs stay high structurally: backhaul spectrum fees take a far larger share of operator revenue than the sub-Saharan norm, a principal reason rural connectivity costs several times what it should (July 2026).

Data Storage

Government runs one shared cloud platform in use across government entities, built as a hybrid of public and private cloud and delivering a full range of as-a-service offerings (2025), and has no policy governing where that data may be hosted, publishing nothing on the platform's usage, security posture or the savings it delivers.

The physical estate is small and recent. ARPCE launched a government data centre at Pointe-Noire in February 2026 to serve the 2Africa cable landing, alongside the Brazzaville facility operating since 2021, and the African Development Bank-funded national data centre was close to complete in August 2025, with an operational launch targeted for 2026. Commercial capacity runs to small operator facilities such as MTN Congo's colocation centre in Brazzaville. The government's digital roadmap commits to sovereign data centres (July 2026).

Whatever is not hosted in country sits a long way from it: no hyperscale cloud provider operates a region in the Republic of the Congo or anywhere in Central Africa, the nearest being South Africa, so cloud services are served remotely at latencies above 100ms (2026). Identity records are held digitally in a centralised database, with biometric capture at regional enrolment centres transmitted to a central production facility.

Energy

Power failure is the ordinary condition of doing business: 77.1% of formal firms experienced outages in the previous fiscal year, at an average of 9.0 a month, both worse than the sub-Saharan African averages (2024).

Just over half the population had access to electricity in 2023, at 51.3%, up marginally on the year before, and the split inside that figure is the story — 69.4% in urban areas against roughly a tenth of the rural population (2023). The Ibrahim Index nonetheless makes access to energy Congo's best-ranked infrastructure measure, 43.6 out of 100 and 24th of 54, and among its most improved indicators over the decade (2023), while infrastructure as a whole is its second-weakest sub-category at 26.4, 47th of 54.

Generation leans on gas: renewables were around a quarter of electricity output in 2021, with the country relying heavily on gas-fired thermal power alongside hydro. The policy machinery is newer than the supply, with an active National Energy Compact for 2025-2030, a dedicated rural electrification agency (ANER), EU-funded work on mini-grid regulation, and pilot deployments including UNDP micro-hydropower studies and the Africa Solaire mini-grid (2025).

Technical Capacity

The state now builds some of its own systems: the Agence congolaise des systèmes d'information built the local-revenue platform PDRCL in house, and the integrated civil-status system SIFEC likewise, rather than procuring it from a foreign supplier (February 2026). The limit shows immediately after the build: SIFEC's final validation workshop recommended that the human, material and financial means for rollout be made available, leaving finished software with no resourced national deployment (February 2026).

Identity systems remain with foreign vendors, who implemented the ID card, ePassport and biometric tax card platforms and continue to run enrolment and production infrastructure (2025). ARPCE, by contrast, has built its own technical and regulatory expertise to license and supervise low-Earth-orbit satellite and high-altitude platform services (October 2025).

The pipeline behind all this is narrow. Several institutions offer tertiary ICT and STEM programmes, led by Marien Ngouabi University's National School of Polytechnic Studies (2025). Government's own capacity to use what they produce is where it was a decade ago: the Ibrahim Index puts effective administration in the bottom half of African states and flat since 2014 (2023), with public administration the weakest of its economic-opportunity sub-categories and falling, and Congo sits in the lower reaches of the UN's e-government ranking (2024).

Cybersecurity

The governance layer beneath the state's core systems is missing: none of the financial management, treasury, tax, customs, human resources, payroll or e-procurement systems has a governance arrangement in place for compliance, security and audit trails (2025).

The law runs ahead of the institutions meant to apply it. Article 74 of Loi n°29-2019 requires data breaches to be notified to the data protection commission within 72 hours, and to affected data subjects where a risk arises — and that commission is among the things an EIB-financed programme is still to create, alongside a national cybersecurity strategy and a CERT. The digital roadmap repeats the commitment to a national security operations centre and a CERT (July 2026).

Responsibility is spread across agencies rather than concentrated. The national information-systems security agency ANSSI sits on the technical committee of the public-administration digitalisation task force, chaired by the digital economy minister alongside ACSI, ADEN, the guichet unique and ARPCE, and ADEN's own remit runs to the fight against cybercrime and the security of networks, data and cyberspace (December 2025).

DPI

Data Exchange

The first thing to move across a government boundary in Congo at scale is a tax payment: FOUTA went live on 3 August 2026, taking declarations filed on E-TAX or, for customs duties, on SYDONIA, authenticating and reconciling each transaction, routing it to the Trésor public and returning a secured electronic receipt. Four banks — BPC, BCI, BGFI and BOA — were connected at launch. Nothing comparable runs anywhere else in the administration. No cross-government exchange platform is operational, and a 2026 UNECA assessment found interoperability frameworks limited and a national data governance strategy only now under development with UNECA and GIZ support; the objectives sit inside the broader Congo Digital 2030 strategy rather than in a strategy of their own. The World Bank's 2025 assessment records no government interoperability framework, no data quality framework and no monitoring of the uptime of government systems, and no dedicated law governs cross-government data sharing, the position resting on the 2019 data protection law with separate cybersecurity and cybercrime legislation.

The reason is institutional before it is technical. Responsibility for identity is split three ways — finance for the tax NIU, interior for the identity card, social affairs for the CAMU and CNSS biometric platform — and the health platform runs its own matching engine rather than drawing on the national identity database. Civil registration is decentralised to municipal officials with no shared platform, electronic records held locally where they exist at all. Where exchange does happen, between the tax, customs and financial management systems, it runs over those systems' own interfaces with no national framework governing it.

The layer is being built twice over. SIFEC, the civil-status platform, is designed to interlink with national identification, tax, education, health and defence, but its February 2026 validation left deployment and resourcing outstanding; extending the Registre Social Unique's data interoperability was named a government priority for 2026; and health and tertiary education systems under the European-financed component of PATN are not yet connected to any operational exchange, whose framework and platform that programme is still to deliver alongside the national data centre.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Congo's tax number has become its identity number. The NIU is issued to every resident and citizen from the age of 6, free of charge and valid for ten years, a credential that began in 2004 as a mandatory taxpayer number and was made biometric in 2020 with iris and fingerprint capture, and whose card production was relaunched in October 2025 after an interruption. It is compulsory for eight economic transactions and five administrative and social formalities, among them opening a bank account, cross-border transfers, telecom subscriptions and criminal-record certificates. The older credential stands beside it rather than under it: the national identity card, created by décret in 2007, is compulsory and legally proves identity and nationality, is open to applicants from age 16 and costs 2,500 CFA francs with its fiscal stamp.

No coverage figure is published for either. The Interior Ministry said in July 2025 that many Congolese hold no valid identity document, producing an absence of official recognition and effective administrative non-existence. Delivery binds as tightly as issuance: in Pointe-Noire alone, 10,506 identity cards issued between 2016 and 2024 and 25,549 NIU cards issued between 2020 and 2024 were still unclaimed in September 2025, prompting a proximity distribution campaign.

That is 36,055 uncollected cards in one city.

There is no deployed digital authentication for the identity card — it carries a barcode and a machine-readable zone, and no infrastructure lets a citizen authenticate online with it — and no digital-identity-specific regulation, with a July 2025 workshop naming the legal and institutional framework as a requirement still to be met and an ordonnance in interministerial preparation. The planned national digital identity system remains at roadmap and validation stage with no operational deployment in early 2026, and the identifier joining civil registration, the identity card and the NIU is still at design stage. Enforcement of the mandates is another matter: a regulator's audit of 18 localities in mid-2025 found SIM cards being sold without any identity document presented in Brazzaville, Pointe-Noire and ten other towns.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The national tax payment rail went live before the Treasury account behind it. FOUTA opened on 3 August 2026 with its pilot complete, payment following a declaration filed on E-TAX or, for customs, on SYDONIA, with each transaction routed to the Trésor public and returned as a secured electronic receipt, while the Compte unique du Trésor at the BEAC that is meant to centralise those receipts is still being finalised and its opening convention is not yet in place; the same 2025 assessment records no treasury single account supported by the financial management system. Four banks were connected at launch and general roll-out to all taxpayers is targeted for the end of 2026. Online payment is not new: E-PAY opened in October 2019 and remains the gateway through which E-TAX filings settle by mobile money or bank transfer.

For households the story is mobile money and only mobile money. Adults holding a mobile-money account rose from 2 percent in 2014 to 37 percent in 2021 while the share holding a bank account was almost unchanged, but only about one in four registered mobile-money accounts is actively used. The market is a duopoly between MTN and Airtel, MTN holding the larger share, and fees have risen since 2019. Access to banking services remains among the country's most improved governance indicators and still one of its lowest-scoring. Opening an account requires the NIU.

The rules are set regionally. BEAC owns 99.2 percent of GIMACPAY, acts as its settlement agent and directly operates the SYGMA and SYSTAC systems Congo participates in; GIMACPAY has treated domestic and cross-border transactions alike since its July 2020 launch, though its scheme rules are not public. Consumer protection comes from BEAC and COBAC instruments of 2024 rather than a national payments law, and the National Financial Inclusion Strategy was still in draft after a third technical review in December 2025. New entrants arrive regardless: a PawaPay subsidiary took an ARPCE aggregator licence in June 2026 to offer one API across operators, banks and microfinance institutions, and a remittance corridor from France and Belgium opened in May 2026.

Registries

The most complete register the Congolese state holds is not of its population. A World Bank completion report in 2024 recorded between 852,149 and 893,000 households — roughly two-thirds of the population — registered in the digital Registre Social Unique, the highest social registry coverage in sub-Saharan Africa. Official reporting in January 2026 still described the registry, in place since 2015, as insufficiently known and used. By contrast there is no established, continuously updated population register at all; a roadmap to build one linked to civil registration has been adopted, and the two are not integrated.

Civil registration is the layer everything else would rest on. Birth registration completeness was measured at 95.9 percent in 2015; the Ibrahim Index scored civil registration at 37.5 out of 100 in 2023, 47th of 54 African states and one of Congo's ten most deteriorated indicators. Rural offices still record births, deaths and marriages on paper. SIFEC, the digital replacement, was built in house by the Agence congolaise des systèmes d'information and cleared final validation at Kintélé in February 2026 across birth, marriage and death modules, but the workshop's principal recommendation was that the means for rollout be made available, leaving the software finished and national deployment unfunded. The first route considered was stranger: as at September 2024 digitisation was under negotiation with FamilySearch, the genealogical body of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, reaching beyond the civil register to the national archives of the former Afrique Équatoriale Française.

The business register is furthest along: a dematerialised single window at monentreprise.acpce.cg covers all departments and communes with online forms and payment. The tax register is a single scheme for natural persons and legal entities alike. A national digital addressing system piloted in Brazzaville from September 2022 and demonstrated in October 2024 has not been rolled out nationally. Almost none of them join up: an identity card requires a birth certificate on paper rather than a database lookup, the voter register is not deduplicated against the identity system, and neither the human resources system nor social insurance uses the national identity number.

Sectoral management information systems

The line ministries run real systems without the controls that would make their output evidential: none of the financial management, treasury, tax, customs, human resources, payroll or e-procurement systems has a governance arrangement in place for compliance, security and audit trails. Beneath it is a conventional off-the-shelf back office. An integrated financial management information system is operational for central government only, on a chart of accounts that captures neither spending linked to the Sustainable Development Goals nor non-financial performance indicators. A customs system is in use, and customs and tax administration have not been merged. Debt management is covered for foreign and domestic debt, but there is no public investment management system: no project database, nothing published on results. Payroll runs on off-the-shelf software while the human resources system is still being implemented, with no self-service and no data exchange, and social insurance and pensions run on custom software, with a separate system for public sector employees, exchanging data with nothing.

Health and education stop at the aggregate. Rural primary healthcare keeps patient records, registers and prescriptions on paper, with DHIS2 used for aggregate reporting at higher administrative levels only, and the 2021 Global Health Security Index found no electronic health record systems in use, even though the universal health insurance fund requires a fingerprint scan at the point of care, on the platform the social security fund also uses. Rural schools record attendance, enrolment and grades in paper registers; an education management information system is being developed under the GPE-financed TRESOR programme, its legal framework established only by decree in November 2023, and the African Union ran an assessment workshop in Brazzaville in May 2026 confirming facility-level capture has not happened.

Where systems face their own users, complaints are minuted. The finance ministry has three standing ones against E-solde, its civil service payroll platform: data security, recurrent unavailability and a malfunctioning QR code on payslips, alongside SIPAE, through which state salaries are processed and dematerialised payslips issued. The national safety net programme launched in 2024 initially targets around 70,000 households and individuals, against roughly 1.48 million households.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

What a Congolese business can do with the state online is pay it, and since July it must. Certified electronic invoicing became compulsory on 1 July 2026 under a décret of 30 March 2026, a three-month compliance window, covering all users of e-invoicing software, one of the two levers the finance minister named for the 2026 tax reform. Filing runs through the E-TAX portal, with payment settled through E-PAY by mobile money or bank transfer. The terms are unforgiving: a declaration is irreversible once sent, with no correction route in the user guide, and a company may appoint only one mandataire at a time, whose delegated filing and payment rights are removed from the legal representative for the duration.

For a citizen there is close to nothing. The 2025 GovTech assessment records no online public service portal or one-stop shop, no government mobile application and no involvement of citizens or businesses in designing e-services, no social insurance or pension portal and no job portal, and no platform for complaints or information requests or for taking part in policy decisions. The one-stop-shop citizen portal promised under the World Bank's digital acceleration project was undelivered as at June 2025. Congo scored 0.3391 on the UN E-Government Development Index in 2024, 166th of 193.

Of the 32 headline questions the 2025 index records for Congo, eight are answered yes, two systems are in implementation and two more are qualified, leaving twenty recorded as absent. Every system the state does run is back-office administration, and it has none of the citizen-facing portals the index assesses.

Coordination is the remaining gap. The GovTech institution exists but publishes no annual report on its results or spending, and no coordination body above it leads GovTech across government. A task force on digitalising the public administration was created under the Prime Minister by decree in July 2026, carrying a national digital roadmap published the same month. The state's own systems agency builds in house, including the local-authority revenue platform validated in February 2026. The e-procurement portal is still being implemented, and publishes nothing to the open contracting standard.

Governance

Legislation and regulation

The newest digital instrument on Congo's statute book creates a committee: Décret n° 2026-261 of 29 July 2026 establishes a task force on digitalising the public administration, placed under the Prime Minister, with its costs falling on the state budget. What the statute book still lacks is anything that would let people outside government see what the machinery produces. There is no right to information legislation requiring government data or documents to be made available online, no entity monitoring compliance, and nothing published on information requests received or granted (2025). There is no dedicated law on cross-government data sharing or interoperability either, and no digital-identity-specific regulation: the 2007 decree behind the national identity card governs the physical card, and an ordonnance on digital identity and data protection was still in interministerial preparation (2025). The general data protection statute of 2019 remains the only broad rights instrument in force, and is dealt with under data protection.

The instruments that do arrive are fiscal. Certified electronic invoicing became compulsory on 1 July 2026 under a decree of 30 March 2026, reaching every natural and legal person supplying, distributing or using e-invoicing terminals or software; presentation of the unique tax number has been compulsory since October 2022 for opening a bank account, subscribing to telecommunications, internet or television service and registering with social security; and a levy on newly imported SIM-equipped digital terminals took effect in June 2026. Parliament's own digital legislating runs mostly through the finance law: in the 2025 budget it raised the operational digital programme by XAF 1.81bn while cutting the ministry's pilotage programme by XAF 7.59bn, leaving the ministry total unchanged. The agency meant to carry the sector, ADEN, was created by loi n° 69-2022 of 16 August 2022 with legal personality and management autonomy.

Day-to-day regulation is ARPCE's. It gave subscribers two months in October 2025 to register their SIM cards or lose the line, and served formal notice on MTN Congo and Airtel Congo in April 2026 over mobile quality of service, under threat of sanction.

Strategies, plans and policies

Congo's national digital roadmap, published in July 2026, opens with digitalising public revenue collection on the ground that most payments for public services are still made in cash, sets five ambitions and nine programmes, and places delivery in an interministerial task force under the Prime Minister rather than in the digital-economy ministry alone. The decree governing that task force lists its objectives as revenue, expenditure control, service quality and job creation, in that order.

Coordinating bodies have multiplied faster than delivery. The task force alone has four organs: a strategic committee of thirteen ministers under the Prime Minister, a steering committee under his deputy, a technical committee seating ANSSI, ACSI, ADEN, the guichet unique and ARPCE, and an investment committee under the finance minister. A separate ministerial steering committee for the digital transformation of public finance management met for the first time on 15 July 2026. ADEN, whose stated remit runs from digital-economy policy and tariff-setting to cybercrime, network security and internet governance, came under resident budgetary control only on 2 December 2025, three years after it was created. Against that apparatus, the 2025 assessment records no whole-of-government approach to public sector digital transformation, with no ministry leading it and no cross-government forum for senior digital officials, no government entity for data governance and no data governance strategy or policy, and no open source policy for the public sector and no national strategy on emerging technologies.

Execution is the thin part. Of the XAF 23.35bn revised 2025 vote for posts, telecommunications and the digital economy, XAF 3.16bn is recorded as executed by 31 December 2025. The coordinator of the flagship PATN programme described its 2025 budget as largely carrying over 2024 activities — those begun but not closed, those finished but unpaid, and those never started. A national financial inclusion strategy was still in draft after a third technical committee review in December 2025. The administrative base is weak: Congo scores 39.7 out of 100 for overall governance, 45th of 54 and essentially unchanged over the decade to 2023, with public administration its weakest foundation for economic opportunity at 38.7.

Regional collaboration

Congo's most load-bearing digital systems are run from outside the country. Its payment rails — the CEMAC instant payment system GIMACPAY and the regional central bank's own RTGS and clearing systems — are owned and operated at regional level by BEAC and GIMAC, and the consumer protections covering electronic payment instruments are regional instruments rather than national law. So is the inclusion target the country is working to: the CEMAC sub-regional strategy for 2022–27 aims to lift financial inclusion from 32 percent in 2021 to 60 percent by 2027 and 75 percent by 2030, and BEAC adopted a regional financial inclusion strategy in February 2025 aimed at low-income and vulnerable populations across the member states.

Physically the estate reaches its neighbours through fibre. The African Development Bank's still-active Central Africa Backbone commitment funds optical fibre on the interconnection links with Cameroon and the Central African Republic, together with a national data centre. People cross more easily than credentials do: Congo formalised free movement within CEMAC in October 2017, admitting passport-holding citizens of the other member states without a visa, and the CEMAC biometric passport is issued and recognised across the bloc.

On the broad measure Congo scores 30.2 out of 100 for regional integration, 42nd of 54 African states and up half a point over the decade to 2023. Its weight inside the regional financial system is nonetheless heavy: outstanding public securities stood at FCFA 2,966.3bn at end-May 2026, close to 30 percent of the CEMAC total and second only to Gabon, with BEAC's national director recommending on 27 July 2026 that the country strengthen its debt and public-financing management strategy. Regional bodies also supply technical help the state does not generate itself: the African Union's education agency held a workshop in Brazzaville in May 2026 to modernise the education management information system, whose facility-level data capture has yet to be digitised.

Standards

The first quality-management certification held by any operator in the country was awarded in March 2026, when Congo Télécom obtained ISO 9001:2015 — a firm-by-firm milestone rather than a national one, which is how standards tend to arrive here. Across government there is no interoperability framework, no data quality framework, no monitoring of government systems' uptime and no guidance for replacing legacy systems (2025), and none of the core administrative systems — financial management, treasury, tax, customs, human resources, payroll and e-procurement — has a governance arrangement for compliance, security or audit trails. No cross-government data exchange platform is operational, and a national data governance strategy is only now being drafted with UNECA and GIZ support (2026).

Identity shows what that costs. Responsibility is split across three ministries — finance for the biometric tax number, interior for the national identity card, social affairs for the health and social security platform — and that health platform runs its own biometric matching engine without drawing on the national ID database (2025).

Where shared rules do exist, enforcement is the weak point. An ARPCE audit over July and August 2025 found SIM cards being sold with no identity document presented in most of the towns it visited, and the regulator convened MTN and Airtel in October 2025 over the failure. It has had more traction setting engineering rules directly, driving the mutualisation and undergrounding of urban fibre alongside the energy regulator (2025), and pressing the two mobile operators on quality of service in April 2026. The rulebook of the regional payment system Congo relies on is not publicly available, though a governance manual and a rules committee exist.

Data protection

The authority that Congolese data protection law answers to is still a deliverable of a foreign loan: creating a Personal Data Protection Commission remains among the outputs of the European Investment Bank's Congo digital transformation loan, alongside a national cybersecurity strategy, a CERT and an interoperability framework. Whether the commission is constituted and supervising was not established as at August 2026.

The statute it would enforce has been in force since 25 November 2020. Loi n°29-2019 of 10 October 2019 covers consent, data minimisation, breach notification and controller obligations, and classifies biometric data as sensitive; it gives data subjects a right of access to their personal data, sets rules on collection, processing, interconnection and transfer, and requires prior authorisation to process biometric data; and its Article 74 requires a breach to be notified to the data protection commission within 72 hours, and to the people affected where they are at risk.

The obligations bite on a state that is collecting more biometrics, not less: the national identity card encodes thumbprint data alongside a photograph, and the health and social security platform captures and matches both fingerprint and facial biometrics (2025), while the route to fix a wrong record runs through the courts — a correction to a national identity card requires a rectifying judgment of a tribunal, and no standing identity-specific oversight mechanism exists. Digital services carry their own asymmetries: a declaration filed through the E-TAX portal is irreversible once sent, with no correction route stated in the user guide (July 2026), and the finance ministry has minuted data security among three standing user complaints against the civil-service payroll platform (March 2026).

For money specifically, protection is regional and partial: technical standards for electronic payment instruments and IT risk rules for supervised payment institutions come from BEAC and COBAC, and IMF staff recommend extending consumer protection to digital financial services, which the existing framework does not cover (2024).

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Congo's digital programme is being built without any channel through which the public can answer back. There is no national platform allowing citizens to take part in policy decision-making — petitions cannot be submitted, anonymous feedback cannot be given, there is no multi-channel access and government responses to citizens are not published — and no platform for complaints, compliments, suggestions or information requests about service delivery, no published service standards such as response times, no accessibility support for users with disabilities, and no evidence of services changed in response to feedback (2025). Behind that sits the absence of any right to information law, and a record of disclosure that is going backwards: disclosure and accessibility of public records both fell over the decade to 2023 and both sit in the bottom half of the continent.

The associational conditions around policy debate have narrowed sharply. Freedom of association and assembly and civil society space are the country's two most deteriorated governance measures over the decade to 2023, each down more than twenty points. Against that, media freedom remains one of its stronger measures while freedom of expression and belief has fallen, and deliberative and participatory governance is its strongest participation measure and rose over the same decade even as the rest of the participation sub-category fell.

Where digital policy direction comes from is stated openly rather than consulted on: the ministerial committee steering the digital transformation of public finances traces its mandate to the president's March 2026 election campaign commitment rather than to a donor programme, which is what sets the order in which the tax and invoicing platforms arrive. There is also no independent read on how any of it lands: none of the governance index's public-perception indicators carry data for Congo, because the survey rounds they draw on have not covered the country. Even the electoral roll stands apart from the identity estate — officials confirmed in October 2025 that the technical prerequisites for biometric voter registration had not been met.

Inclusion

Digital divides

Congo's exclusion is a problem of use rather than reach: 4G reached 86% of the population while only 19% actually used mobile internet (June 2026). Four in five people who could be online are not, and the shortfall is not explained by masts. It is sharpest outside the two cities. Most rural Congolese are beyond 4G and a large share have no mobile signal at all (2026), and rural electrification stands at a small fraction of the urban rate (2023), so the divide begins below the network layer. The National Development Plan 2022-2026 and the World Bank-financed PATN project both commit to equitable digital access against a persistent urban-rural gap and deep rural poverty; delivery so far has been a handful of rural localities newly carrying 3G (October 2025) and two more connected by the universal service fund (January 2026).

The other lines are money, schooling and familiarity with the technology itself. IMF staff find financial exclusion in Congo driven by income, wealth, education, financial literacy and awareness of digital technology, with the gender gap wider for mobile money than for banking (2021) — the gap widens precisely where the service is digital. How wide it is nationally is not measured: GSMA's 2025 mobile gender gap survey samples only a subset of low- and middle-income countries and does not cover Congo, and the 29% gap it reports is a Sub-Saharan African regional average. Smartphone adoption remains limited (2026), with no published national rate.

On the continental measures the country sits near the floor. Inclusion and Equality is Congo's worst-ranked sub-category in the Ibrahim Index, close to the bottom of the 54 African states measured and flat over the decade to 2023, with equal socioeconomic opportunity among its ten weakest indicators and lower than ten years earlier; internet and computer access is the country's weakest digital measure of all and has barely moved in ten years. Against that, the GSMA scores national digital policy well under half marks (June 2026).

Access to services

Unbanked Congolese adults name cost before anything else: lack of money is cited more often than the CEMAC and sub-Saharan African averages, with documentation requirements and cost next (2021). Price and paperwork sit at the centre of exclusion: the national identity card is a compulsory credential that is not free, produced at two centres only. Collection, not issuance, is the binding constraint: cards made years ago sat unclaimed in Pointe-Noire (September 2025). The Interior Ministry says many Congolese hold no valid identity document and are effectively administratively non-existent (July 2025).

Formal finance reaches few: account ownership at a bank or other financial institution stood at 18 percent of adults in 2021, five percentage points below 2017, the growth in inclusion coming from mobile money rather than banks. Borrowing and saving stay largely informal: 10 percent of adults borrow formally or by mobile money against 24 percent from friends and family, and 19 percent save informally against 20 percent formally (2021). Supply is concentrated: banks held 84 percent of the sector's balance sheet in 2021 and the three largest of ten banks about 49 percent of banking assets at end-2023, while credit to the private sector rose from 6 percent of GDP in 2011 to 15 percent in 2023, still well below the sub-Saharan African average.

No public service is obtainable online: there is no citizen-facing portal, no government mobile application, no complaints channel and no accessibility support for users with disabilities (2025). Healthcare under the universal health insurance fund requires a fingerprint match at the point of service. On the continental measure of equal access to public services Congo ranks near the bottom and has slipped over the decade to 2023.

Non-nationals are reached by programme, not entitlement: Congo hosts over 65,000 refugees and asylum seekers, most from the Central African Republic and the DRC, and has extended the Lisungi safety net to refugee-hosting areas since 2021, with 2,162 refugee households receiving conditional cash transfers in 2023 (February 2024), set against a national safety net whose initial target is itself a small fraction of Congolese households (August 2024).

Technology

AI

No artificial intelligence strategy had been adopted in the Republic of the Congo as at August 2026, and no artificial intelligence system was in operation in government.

ICT Industry

Nothing in Congolese public policy is built to grow a domestic technology industry: as at 2025 the state had no policy to support GovTech startups or private investment in them, put no public money into innovation by startups or small firms, and gave no procurement preference to bids from startups or smaller enterprises. What the state does buy, it buys abroad. The digital identity programme names the French supplier Thales as a partner (July 2025), and the same programme extends to biometric tooling for the police technique et scientifique and a demonstration of Thales's investigation software for building court files. The country's first private industrial telecom network, at the Banga Kayo oil field, was built by Airtel Congo with Wing Wah, a subsidiary of China's Southernpec (August 2025).

The domestic side of the sector is a small number of operators and platforms. Congo Télécom became the first operator in the country to hold ISO 9001:2015 quality-management certification (March 2026). The consumer platform market is served by foreign-backed entrants and turns over quickly: the super-app Gozem launched in Brazzaville in November 2025, while Yango has left the same market.

Firms trade in conditions that make any of this harder. Congo's business and competition regulation sits near the bottom of the 54 African states scored, and has not improved over the decade to 2023, even though economic opportunity is the country's most improved governance category over the same period; most formal firms go through power outages several times a month (2024). Company formation is the exception that works: the business registration agency runs a fully dematerialised single window covering every department and commune, with online filing, payment and electronic delivery of documents.

Innovation ecosystem

Private money has begun to appear where public money does not. Brazzaville delivery platform Noki Noki raised a US$3 million seed round in 2024, and Fondation BantuHub and L'Archer Group launched a EUR 1 million venture capital fund aimed at Congolese startups and small firms in 2025. Against that, the state contributes no public financing to startups or small firms for innovation and no procurement preference for their bids.

The public sector does not innovate on its own account either. As at 2025 Congo had no strategy or programme to improve public sector innovation, no government entity or innovation lab responsible for it, no collaboration with the private sector on it, and published nothing on innovation results; there is likewise no national strategy on emerging technologies and no open source policy for the public sector. The one legislative move in this direction has stalled: a start-up label adopted in law in 2022 had still not been brought into effect by 2025. The supporting infrastructure is a handful of hubs, Jokkolabs Congo among them (2024).

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The United States and the American platform companies held no recorded stake in Congo's digital infrastructure, financing or platform operations as at August 2026.

China activities

China Eximbank is by a wide margin the largest recorded financier of Congo's digital sector, ahead of the World Bank, the European institutions and the African Development Bank; all of its lending was contracted in 2017, and all of it went to fibre and telecommunications coverage rather than to systems or services.

What that money bought is a Huawei build. Phase 3 of the National Telecommunication Coverage Project runs under a commercial contract signed with Huawei Technologies on 13 July 2015 that extends fibre optic cable nationwide, including the Ouesso–Impfondo link, connections to district administrative centres and last-kilometre fibre to institutions, businesses and households, with capacity building for the state incumbent Congo Telecom.

The build has not gone to plan. Implementation stalled after the fall in oil prices left Congo unable to meet its debt obligations to China Eximbank, restarted only after a debt restructuring agreement signed in 2019, and was still under way in April 2022.

Chinese presence also reaches past the state network. Airtel Congo and Wing Wah, a subsidiary of China's Southernpec, have built Congo's first private industrial telecom network, serving the Banga Kayo oil field (August 2025). In March 2026 the modernisation of the Congo-Ocean Railway became the subject of a partnership with China to bring in the BeiDou satellite navigation system, which would place Chinese positioning technology in the country's main transport corridor.

EU activities

Congo's identity systems are built and maintained by European vendors: Mühlbauer of Germany implemented the national ID card, ePassport and NIU biometric tax card platforms between 2018 and 2020 and continues to run the enrolment and production infrastructure, Thales of France is technical partner for the planned unified digital identity project, and Innovatrics of Slovakia built the CAMU/CNSS platform with Akieni as local integrator (2025).

European money is concentrated in a single programme. The European Investment Bank has lent EUR 36.3 million across two tranches for the Congo Digital Transformation programme, running from 2022 to 2028, alongside a European Commission grant of EUR 4,499,959 under a contribution convention with the EIB over the same period to modernise the information systems of the public administration, and an earlier Commission blending grant of EUR 3,750,000 committed in 2021 and running to 2031, which aims among other objectives at the national and international transmission network and at national data processing and storage capacity. All three remain active, and together they form the European limb of the PATN digital transformation programme, which the World Bank also finances and whose EU-funded component began operational deployment in November 2024.

What that has produced so far is partial. Priority IT systems for the health sector, focused on epidemic management, and for tertiary education are under implementation under the EU and EIB-financed component, and neither sector is yet connected to an operational cross-government data exchange (2025).

European reach extends past the programme. The regulator's satellite work runs to European operators, with ARPCE meeting Eutelsat and OneWeb in October 2025, and in May 2026 DigiPay, founded in Brazzaville, and Belmoney, licensed by the National Bank of Belgium, opened a remittance corridor from France and Belgium into Congo and the Democratic Republic of Congo on a remittances-as-a-service model.

Every European and multilateral commitment on the record apart from the African Development Bank's backbone loan dates from 2021 or later, and the weight of it sits on public-administration modernisation, data protection and cybersecurity rather than on network build.

India activities

No Indian state financing, vendor contract or infrastructure holding in Congo's digital sector is on the record as at August 2026.

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf or Emirati investment, data-centre holding or vendor presence in Congo's digital sector is on the record as at August 2026.

Capacity

Literacy

Congo now finishes most of the pupils it starts, and starts fewer of them: Education Completion scored 86.3 out of 100 in 2023, sixth of 54 African states and up 10.8 points over the decade, while Education Enrolment fell 5.2 points to 38.5, thirty-first of 54. The quality of what is taught has not moved with it — 27.7 out of 100 in 2023, 42nd of 54 and flat across the same ten years, with no measure at all returned for teacher supply and training.

The system that would show any of this changing is still on paper. Rural primary schools record attendance, enrolment and grades in paper registers, an education management information system is under development rather than in use, and in May 2026 the African Union's education-development institute ran a workshop in Brazzaville to help the country assess and modernise it. An independent technical assessment in 2024 called the enabling environment for education data weak and fragile, leaning on donor-financed, centrally compiled school directories rather than on capture at the school itself.

Below schooling sits the digital floor, and it is uneven by gender. Financial exclusion in Congo tracks income, wealth, education, financial literacy and familiarity with digital technology, and the gap between women and men is wider for mobile money than for banking (2021) — the more digital the service, the further behind women are.

Training and skills

Most digital skills training in Congo is a line item inside someone else's infrastructure project. PATN's approved 2025 work plan puts training for 1,200 young people in digital skills alongside connecting the universities and further ministries (March 2025), and the World Bank's Congo Digital Acceleration Project, running to 2027, funds digital skills development alongside broadband and digital financial services. Government's own effort is narrower than either: a strategy for basic digital skills in the public sector, with nothing published on what it has delivered (2025).

Tertiary provision is small but genuine. Marien Ngouabi University's National School of Polytechnic Studies (ENSP) teaches computer science, electronics and telecommunications, with Denis Sassou Nguesso University, the Congo University of Science and Technology and private institutes alongside it (2025). Teacher training, the input that would lift the school system feeding those degrees, is the one part of education the country returns no measure for at all.

Research institutions

Research capacity in Congo sits inside the universities rather than in institutes of its own: Marien Ngouabi University, Denis Sassou Nguesso University and the Congo University of Science and Technology carry the country's engineering and computing faculties (2025). No national research institution dedicated to digital technology, data or artificial intelligence was in operation as at August 2026.

Digitalisation

Rural digital data capture

What has reached rural Congo over the past year is coverage rather than records: 3G service was commissioned in sixteen rural localities across six departments, covering more than 30,000 people (October 2025), and the universal access fund FASUCE has begun acting as a delivery body in its own right rather than only a financier, connecting the localities of Miaba and Ehota in January 2026.

The records themselves are still made by hand. Rural civil registration offices write births, deaths and marriages on paper, and the national digital civil registration platform SIFEC reached a technical validation workshop in Brazzaville in February 2026 without being deployed anywhere, rural areas included. Rural primary clinics keep patient records, registers and prescriptions entirely on paper, with DHIS2 support and tablets used for aggregate reporting at higher administrative levels rather than at the facility. Rural primary schools record attendance, enrolment and grades in paper registers, the education management information system being built under the GPE-financed TRESOR programme having had its legal framework set only in November 2023. Where a rural Congolese meets a digital system at all, it is usually by travelling to it: identity card and passport production is concentrated in Brazzaville, with a second centre installed at Pointe-Noire.

The improvement the country can point to outside the cities is economic rather than administrative. Rural Economy is Congo's most improved governance sub-category, up 10.3 points over 2014-2023 to 55.2 out of 100 and 34th of 54, and rural representation and participation is its single most improved indicator after laws on violence against women, up 29.0 points to 58.3 (2023). Rural market access moved the other way over the same decade, down 8.4 points to 56.7, while rural land and water access rose to 60.8 and support to the rural economy to 44.9. The PATN is explicitly aimed at underserved rural populations and the National Development Plan 2022-2026 commits to equitable digital access, against rural poverty running at roughly two-thirds of the rural population (2024) and an electricity gap between town and country that the ICT infrastructure record sets out.

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The first digital system built for Congo's local authorities collects their money, and it is not yet in service: the PDRCL, a platform to dematerialise local-authority revenue collection, reached final validation at a workshop closing on 12 February 2026, built in-house by the state's systems agency ACSI under the finance ministry.

Beneath that the administrative tier runs on its own. Civil registration is decentralised to municipal officials with no shared digital platform, and electronic records, where they exist, are held locally rather than exchanged automatically with other government systems (2022). Work on data exchange and interoperability is coordinated at central government level, led by the Ministry of Posts, Telecommunications and the Digital Economy with the national regulatory and cybersecurity agencies. The one system designed with a municipal authority in the room has not left the capital: ARPCE's national digital addressing system was piloted in Brazzaville from September 2022 and demonstrated in October 2024 to a steering committee including the cadastre authority and Brazzaville city hall, but has not been rolled out nationally. Where the state does reach people locally it does so as a campaign rather than a service: uncollected national identity and tax-number cards were handed out through a proximity distribution drive from September 2025, framed around revision of the electoral roll.

Data

National statistics

A national statistics dissemination platform, Hiswaca, was launched in January 2026, giving access to economic, demographic and social indicators in downloadable and API-accessible formats under a World Bank-financed West and Central Africa statistics harmonisation project. It arrives on top of a statistical system the Ibrahim Index scores at 26.4 out of 100 for capacity, 50th of 54 African states and 2.4 points weaker than a decade earlier (2023).

The Institut National de la Statistique counted about 6.1 million people in the 2023 census. The economic base is where the gap sits: no business or economic census has been run in the past twenty years, and of the survey rounds registered over the past decade two are health surveys and one a household survey, with no labour force or business survey among them (2023), which leaves employment and enterprise statistics without a recent instrument. The IMF works from the same shortage: the most recent Enterprise Survey data for Congo dates to 2009, so the case on small-business access to finance is argued from a fifteen-year-old survey (2024).

On the World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators the weakest showing is on data services and data sources — how the office serves its users, and where it gets its raw material — in the 20-49 per cent band against 50-69 per cent on data use, data products and data infrastructure (2023). The administrative record behind those pillars is thin in the same way: an independent panel reviewing the education sector in June 2024 found the enabling environment for education data weak and fragile, leaning on donor-financed, centrally compiled school directories rather than facility-level digital capture. Public opinion is missing outright — none of the Ibrahim Index's public-perception indicators carry any data for Congo, because the Afrobarometer rounds they draw on have not covered the country (2023).

Open data

Congo has no open data portal: no government dataset is published through a central open data platform or made available by public API (2025). The one channel that has opened since is the statistics office's own — the dissemination platform launched in January 2026 came out of a donor-financed statistics project rather than a government disclosure policy, and covers indicators rather than government records.

What the statistical system does publish is scored low and capped low. Open Data Watch's 2024 inventory puts the country's best categories at national accounts and food security on 5 out of 10, then the built environment and population and vital statistics on 4.5, with nothing above 5. Five categories score zero — digital development, labour, money and banking, pollution and poverty — meaning nothing usable is published in any of them.

Across the 23 categories recorded, mean openness comes to 2.9 out of 10 (2024).

Disclosure of government records is both weak and getting weaker: Disclosure of Public Records scores 25.9 out of 100, 37th of 54 and down 7.5 points over the decade, and Accessibility of Public Records 20.4, 40th of 54 and down 4.1 (2023). Nothing compels publication: there is no right to information legislation requiring government data to be made available online, no entity monitoring compliance, and no reporting of information requests received or granted (2025). The framework that would sit above all of this is still being drafted — a National Data Governance Strategy is only now under development, with UNECA and GIZ support, and no cross-government data exchange platform is operational (2026).

Use of satellite data

No national space agency, earth observation programme or geospatial data policy had been established in Congo as at August 2026. The regulator's satellite work runs to communications rather than observation: ARPCE met the European operators Eutelsat and OneWeb in October 2025 to build its expertise on telecommunications satellites. The other satellite thread on the record is positioning, not imagery — China's BeiDou navigation system has been proposed to modernise the Congo-Ocean Railway (March 2026).

Finance

New investments

Congo's newest digital money is European, and aimed at the machinery of government rather than at pipes. The European Investment Bank has lent the Republic of Congo EUR 36.3 million across two tranches for the Congo Digital Transformation programme, running to 2028, and the European Commission has committed a grant of EUR 4,499,959 under a contribution convention with the EIB to modernise public administration information systems, alongside an earlier EUR 3,750,000 grant of 2021 for transmission and data storage capacity. Deployment of the EU-funded component began in November 2024.

The anchor remains the World Bank's Congo Digital Acceleration Project, an IBRD loan of US$100 million committed in June 2022 and running to 2027, which also funds identity and civil-status digitisation. Older is the African Development Bank's XDR 44,114,505 commercial loan for the Congo component of the Central Africa Backbone, signed in 2016 and still active, funding 550 kilometres of cross-border fibre and a data centre. Chinese lending of 2017 for the National Telecommunication Coverage Project fared worse: the project stalled when falling oil prices left Congo unable to service its China Eximbank debt, restarted after a 2019 restructuring, and was still under implementation in April 2022.

Little of it reaches firms. Gozem launched in Brazzaville in November 2025 on the back of a Series B round backed by MSC's shipping arm and Al Mada Ventures; the only other is a MIGA political risk guarantee of USD 6 million, since closed, over an equity investment in Airtel Mobile Commerce's Congolese subsidiary.

Around a dozen external digital-sector commitments are on the record, spanning 2016 to 2025 and worth on the order of half a billion US dollars. Nearly all goes to the state rather than to firms, mostly as sovereign lending rather than grant. Connectivity takes the bulk, ahead of public-administration systems and payments. The split is chronological: Chinese loans were all contracted in 2017 for telecommunications coverage, while European and multilateral money dates mostly from 2021 or later and leans towards administration, data protection and cybersecurity. China Eximbank is still the largest single financier, at roughly half the total.

MoUs and other agreements

No digital-sector memorandum of understanding or framework agreement involving the Republic of the Congo was on the record as at August 2026.

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